

Q. After Maharashtra, are we entering an Opposition-mukt Bharat?
A. I have seen many governments, worked with Narasimha Rao, Rajiv Gandhi, Deve Gowda, Atal Behari Vajpayee, Manmohan Singh, but have never seen such a vindictive government. An elected government [in Maharashtra] has been toppled by money, ED-CBI, what not! I believe the government will not continue because it is unethical, undemocratic, illegal.

Q. What about Shiv Sena switching sides and forming the government with NCP-Congress in 2019?
A. I am talking about now and future. Why should the Union home minister say I will end dynastic rule and occupy Bengal? You can bulldoze democracy but in the next election people will bulldoze you.

Q. The BJP has taken a national political resolution to end dynastic rule...
A. What dynasty? In sports, you (Amit Shah) have taken over a top post. Is this not dynasty? You are talking about one person in my family who has been elected twice. What's the harm in accepting the young generation?

Q. Do you accept the Opposition lacks a prominent, tall leader to counter Narendra Modi?
A. The 2024 polls will be a vote to reject BJP. Why are naming Modi? Is he God? Look at the situation of the country—price hike, inflation, unemployment. From where have you got the money to provide luxury and other things for people (MLAs) who camped in Assam?

Q. This is a serious allegation, be specific.
A. No I won't. Sometimes it's better to remain silent.

Q. The Centre levels the same allegations at you—unemployment, no investment, targeting critics.
A. The propaganda is to defame us. Employment in Bengal increased by 40 per cent. Our economy has grown 3.5 times, revenue saw four times increase and even during the pandemic we posted a positive 1.2 per cent growth, whereas India's growth was in the negative. The Centres owes us Rs 98,000 crore and another Rs 28,000 crore for rural development. They are conspiring to put an economic blockade against us.

Q. People are saying, when the Opposition cannot unite for the presidential polls, how will they unite before 2024?
A. True, Opposition is badly divided. If we fail this time, people will not excuse us. Yashwant Sinha's name came from the Opposition, I did not suggest it. But I am supporting him.

"True, the Oppossition is badly divided. People want us to fight unitedly and if we fail this time they will not excuse us"

Q. Now that the Centre has announced an Adivasi name, will you support her? If she is in Kolkata will you meet her?
A. We don't do caste politics. If they had told us (about Draupadi Murmu's candidature) we would have at least discussed her Why won't I meet her? But I cannot betray (the Opposition).

Q. But aren't you expanding your party at the cost of Congress? Rahul Gandhi is also saying this.
A. Oh my God! You (Rahul) cannot tell me what to do. (Why don't) you go to the grassroots, make the party strong? I will do my own business.

Q. But Congress is an important glue for Opposition unity.
A. Why only Congress, Congress, Congress? I don't have any interest for any big post. Sometimes you need to bell the cat. I only want my country to develop so that the young should get employment...to build a united India.

Q. You have issued a look-out notice against Nupur Sharma....
A. Why wasn't she arrested? We want to arrest her because you cannot play with fire. BJP is spending money for spreading fake, communal news which is dividing our country.

Q. What about the charge that you're going for an Opposition-mukt Bengal. You take back people who joined BJP.
A. We don't need to horse-trade. They are willingly coming to us as they want to boycott hate politics.

Q. There's talk that incidents like Bagtui happened as you cannot control your cadres.
A. I am proud of my cadres. Rampurhat (Bagtui) was the fall out of a local problem. But it was the BJP's conspiracy to bring in the CBI.

Q. As the only woman CM in the country, have you ever been treated differently?
A. Honestly, I always see myself as a human being, not just a woman. But maybe because of it they (NDA) are not giving me money and creating economic blockades. ■